



△ BEAUTY IN SIMPLICITY

This image reveals the beautifully pure and simple exteriors of Ferapontov's buildings: from left to right, the Church of St. Martinian, the Church of the Nativity of the Virgin, the Bell Tower, and the Church of the Annunciation.



△ VIBRANT INTERIOR

The fresco of Christ Pantocrator ("Ruler of All") inside the dome of the Church of the Nativity of the Virgin at Ferapontov Monastery was painted around 1502 by Russian artist Dionisy.

Český Krumlov Castle

A castle complex built in the 14th–19th centuries on a rocky promontory shaped by the Vltava River



Český Krumlov Castle was founded in the mid-13th century by the powerful Witgonen family, then lords of Krumlov. It passed through the hands of three more noble Czech families—the Rosenbergs (1302–1602), the Eggenbergs (1602–1719), and the Schwarzenbergs (1719–1947)—before being handed to the Czech state in 1947. Declared a national monument in 1989, it became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1992.

Homage to history

The castle grew to incorporate over 40 buildings—including palaces, stables, a salt-house, a brewery, and a dairy—built around five courtyards and a large formal garden. Its buildings reflect a range of architectural styles, from the Gothic to the Renaissance and Baroque. Among them is the Gothic *Hrádek* ("Little Castle") with its beautiful Renaissance facade, tower, and frescoes, and a Baroque theater from 1766 that is the most complete example of its kind in the world. Krumlov's massive ramparts are a reminder of the castle's original—and never seriously tested—defensive function, while the theater and the bears that inhabit the moat are a curious reminder of its history as an important social and cultural hub in Southern Bohemia.

▽ TOWERING ABOVE

The brightly painted, part-Gothic, part-Renaissance six-story Castle Tower has a belfry and a galleried balcony leading up to the clockworks, which enclose the clock bells.

